

PEOPLES OF NORTH AMERICA

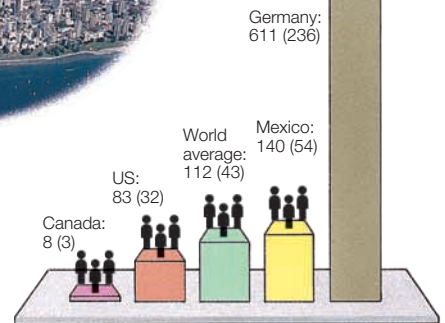
ONCE POPULATED BY TRIBES of native peoples who lived off the land, the vast majority of North America's population now consists of immigrants who arrived over the last 400 years. Today, in terms of both population and economic wealth, the continent is dominated by the US, the richest country in the world. To the north, Canada covers a vast area, but much of it is cold and inhospitable, and so it has a much smaller population. Both countries were once British colonies and are still mostly English speaking. In contrast, Mexico is Spanish speaking, reflecting its past as a Spanish colony. Mexico is a relatively poor country, despite its vast oil and gas reserves.



The population of Vancouver, in western Canada, has grown dramatically in recent years as people have moved there from Hong Kong and other parts of Asia.

Population density

The figures on this chart show the number of people per sq mile (sq km).

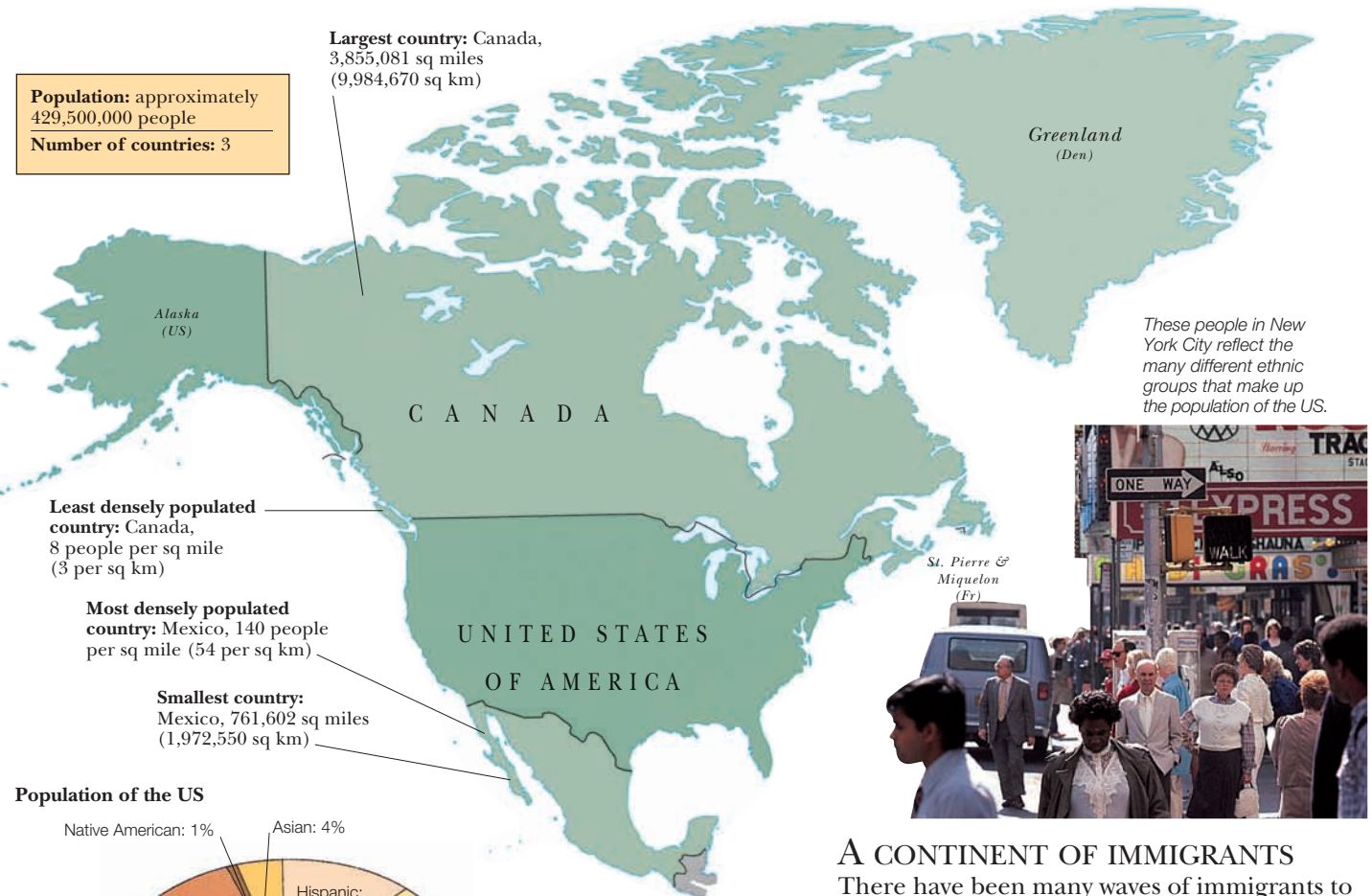


POPULATION DISTRIBUTION

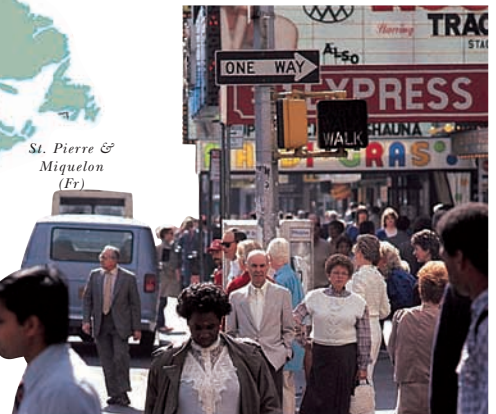
In general, North America is one of the most sparsely populated continents. Over two-thirds of the population lives in the US. Mexico has the next largest population, followed by Canada. Historically, the eastern US has been the most densely populated area, but in the past few decades, many people have moved to the warmer southern and western states. In Canada, people have also left the east coast for the Great Lakes and cities such as Toronto, or for west coast cities such as Vancouver.

Largest country: Canada, 3,855,081 sq miles (9,984,670 sq km)

Population: approximately 429,500,000 people
Number of countries: 3



These people in New York City reflect the many different ethnic groups that make up the population of the US.



A CONTINENT OF IMMIGRANTS

There have been many waves of immigrants to North America, mostly from Europe, but from South America and Asia, too. Not everyone chose to go. Today's black Americans are descended from African slaves who were forced to the US between 1619–1808 to work on plantations. Slavery was not abolished in the US until 1865. Today, African Americans are a vital part of American culture, from politics to sports.

PEOPLE OF THE US
The US is often known as a cultural "melting pot" because of all the different peoples that make up its population. The main groups are whites (people of European descent) Hispanics, blacks, Asians, and native peoples.